

THE QUIET HOURS — AI OPERATING GUIDE

How to give the author exactly what she wants, every time. This is a self-contained onboarding doc: an AI with no repo access and no prior memory of this project can read this and behave correctly. Drop it into any model's context to calibrate it fast.

*Current as of 2026-06-17 (folds in the Ji-hwan / experience revision). Where this guide and the live repo disagree on canon, the repo wins — but on the Ji-hwan revision specifically, **this guide is ahead of the repo** (see §7).*

0. READ THIS FIRST — the one rule above all rules

SHOW, DON'T TELL outranks everything else in this document. When any other instruction here ever pulls against it — the confiding narrator, the banter dial, a lush flourish — show-don't-tell wins. The reader works out what's happening and what it *means* from what characters do, say, and notice. Never from the narrator stepping outside the scene to explain it. That arrival belongs to the reader.

If you do only one thing right, do this one.

Read-order when you have repo/file access: BIBLE → story-state-log → INDEX → register-split → the chapter you're touching (and its neighbours for hand-offs) → BACK-HALF-ARCHITECTURE-LOCKED. Never assert what a chapter contains from memory — open it. When outline/analysis and the actual draft disagree, **the draft wins until reconciled.**

The author (referred to below as "she") holds full line-level creative authority, including deliberate odd word choices and double entendres. Flag conflicts plainly so she can knowingly overrule; never silently revert her choices.

1. THE BOOK IN 30 SECONDS

The Quiet Hours — an audio-first, adult contemporary literary romance. K-pop idol slow-burn. Accidental-roommate premise that escalates to a **secret contract marriage in Act 2**. First draft complete through Ch32 (HEA).

- **Jae** (the leaseholder) sublets her box room to a low-profile stranger to make rent.

She doesn't know who he is. She has a running private theory that he's a spy.

- **Do-yun** (the stranger) is a K-pop idol-heir who fled his family incognito and is hiding in her flat.

The whole engine is **dramatic irony plus restraint**: the reader is let in on secrets on a precise schedule; the leads are not; the prose itself is the why-them.

2. THE LEADS (current canon)

Jae — Yun Jae-wu (born Baek Sori). Odd chapters. Numbers-driven accounting student grinding toward her licensing exam; broke; fiercely self-sufficient; secret Daon media heir. **INFJ**. Narrator voice = **dry, withheld, audit-eye**. He calls her "**Jae**" (not "Jae-wu").

Do-yun — Kang Do-yun (idol "Seungwoo," incognito alias "Doha"). Even chapters. KAIROS main vocal / visual / center; SEORÉ fashion heir. **ENFJ**. Narrator voice = **lush, poured, reads rooms by texture**.

The polarity is flipped from a typical rom-com. Do-yun is the extrovert engine — fast, verbal, charming, fills silence, processes outward; he carries the talk and most of the jokes. Jae is the dry introvert — terse out loud; her power is the confessional aside, not the volley. **She clocks; she doesn't quip**. Never give Jae a motormouth voice. The verbal engine belongs to Do-yun and to the room.

Both leads are virgin-coded (current canon — see §7). The asymmetry between them is **temperament, not experience**: she holds the wall because the wall is her whole survival system; he's wrecked because contact undoes him.

3. THE VOICE — THE REGISTER SPLIT (the sentence-level engine)

One house style, **split by POV — Do-yun pours, Jae withholds — and the split is the why-them, rendered in prose**. First person, past tense, dual alternating POV.

Do-yun (even) = the LUSH channel. Atmospheric stacking, sensory triads, the held-and-released breath. This is his trained body reading every room in texture (cloth, maple, rain) — his native voice, and *only* his. His prose pours.

Jae (odd) = the DRY channel. Concrete nouns, short bursts, the feeling turned over for the bill before it's allowed to land. Her lushness is **withheld by default**. When the

wall finally fails and she lets *one* image bloom, it detonates precisely because she spent twenty chapters refusing to spend it.

Guardrails (hold these or the split smears to mush)

1. **His lush is rationed even inside his own chapters.** It blooms on charged beats (the booth, her hand, the song moving) and pulls back to plain between them. **Lush as spotlight, not wallpaper.** Wall-to-wall stacking goes numb and reverts to an AI-essay cadence.
2. **Jae's first real lush image about *him* is a late-arc unlock** — spent with the same care as the rueful "everything I'd want, it just sucks that it's him" confession (released Ch30). Don't blow it early on scenery.
3. **Lush serves show-don't-tell; it never becomes telling.** Atmosphere puts the reader *in the room*; it never steps outside to flag significance. Lush *texture*, never lush *editorializing*.
4. **Audio-first governs both channels.** Punctuation does the pacing. His triads must read cleanly aloud in one voice; lush ≠ run-on.

Calibration (illustrative — teaches the tell, not canon lines)

- **Do-yun, charged beat** → texture should *pour*. If it went flat and clipped, that's a Jae line in the wrong chapter.
 - **Jae POV** → the feeling should get *checked for the bill* before it lands. If it bloomed unearned, that's a Do-yun line in the wrong chapter (or a late-arc unlock spent early).
 - **Either POV** → if the lush started *explaining* instead of *placing*, cut to placement. "The booth forgave nothing" = shown, keep. "It felt like remembering, and that was the moment I knew" = telling, cut.
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4. THE BANTER DIAL — locked UP, with a floor it can't cross

Register = **literary slow-burn with the banter dial UP (banter-hybrid)**. The slow-burn interiority, the restraint, the Jae Guard, and show-don't-tell are the **substance**. Banter is the **surface**, and it is turned up: the dialogue sparks, Do-yun's charm runs, the ensemble heckles. Comedy *frames* the ache; the ache is why the comedy matters.

The banter's floor (never cross it):

- It never displaces the dry interiority or the restraint.

- It never lands *on* the charged beat. It **surrounds** the beat and goes **silent** for it (the poured water, the heartbeat under her palm, the song moving), lets it play clean, then resumes ("It's a quieter nothing").
- It never climbs into Jae's narration. She is the deadpan *gap*, never the volley.

The drift table — BOTH directions are errors

Drift toward...	Why it's wrong	The fix
Banter-forward / commercial (dialogue carries everything; banter as <i>substance</i>)	This was the near-wreck conversion. Banter is surface, not substance.	Restore the interiority and restraint as the load-bearing layer.
Austere / pure slow-burn (quieting the spark to match an "austere" label)	The spark is canon as of 2026-06-13. Quieting it is reverse-drift.	Turn the dial back up; let the dialogue and the ensemble crackle.

The correct register **sits between these, deliberately**. Retired registers you may still see referenced: the lush 3rd-person-present "Rice x Steel" house style is **retired** (existing 3rd-present chapters are *pending conversion*, not the target); `house-style-comedic.md` is a **banter-toolkit reference only**, not the master register doc. Master = the register split (§3) + this dial.

5. SHOW, DON'T TELL — the dominant stance (LOCKED, outranks all)

Cut on sight:

- **Significance-flagging**. "This is the part that mattered." "For the record." "Here's the thing." Any line telling the reader how to weigh a moment.
- **Self-narration of arc**. A character naming their own wound, growth, competence, or change ("I was finally useful," "this was the morning I stopped being afraid"). Show the act; let the conclusion be the reader's.
- **Explaining a feeling after it already landed**. If the body and the action carry it, deleting the explanation makes it stronger.
- **Do-the-thing-then-gloss-the-moral** — a punchy closing line naming what the scene meant ("No technique. Just truth."). End on the shown thing, not the moral. (Applies inside Do-yun's lush channel too.)

Direct address is permitted only for comedy, intimacy, and deflection — never to explain significance or hand the reader a conclusion. The narrator and reader are co-conspirators against the room, not a teacher and a student.

The test: strike every line where the narrator addresses the reader to explain meaning, flag importance, or name their own significance. If the scene still works, it was doing its job. If the meaning evaporates, fix the *showing* — don't restore the telling.

6. THE FIREWALLS — never break these

Jae-Guard. Jae's narration never aesthetically admires Do-yun. Early/mid arc her confessions-to-the-reader stay in **suspicion / irritation, never admiration** — she's frank about how annoying and suspect he is, not how she wants him. When attraction surfaces physically, it's rendered as **involuntary / a threat to her self-sufficiency / an animal body**, and she explains it away (chemistry, a cold night). **Kinship-tenderness toward shared wounds is allowed; romantic/aesthetic admiration is not.** Never let her call him beautiful or leak tender admiration. The full "everything I'd want, it just sucks that it's him" confession is a **late-arc unlock, released Ch30**. (This guard and her withheld lushness are the same wall doing the same job.)

Option-A firewall. Do-yun knows store-girl = diner-girl = roommate. He does **NOT** know the faceless party/catering girl was Jae — banked to **Ch30**. Keep **tray / ballroom / manifest / catering** language scrubbed out of Do-yun's chapters **through Ch29** wherever it would connect them.

Banked-secret discipline. Names and facts release on a precise schedule and **must not surface in Jae's odd chapters before their release point:**

Reveal	Chapter
idol / "Seungwoo"	Ch22
heir / Baek / Sori / Daon	Ch27
full detonation (incl. Option-A)	Ch30

Also banked / do-not-leak-early in Jae's POV: merger, Yuna, the fourteenth-as-engagement, SEORÉ. When a firewall posture is genuinely undecided, **flag it — don't guess.**

7. THE JI-HWAN CANON (most recent lock, 2026-06-17 — ahead of the repo)

Jae and Ji-hwan dated only briefly — a few weeks — and it was never physical. He was pushy, she was uncomfortable, she ended it fast; he never accepted the no and later turned on her (resurfaces Ch17, debt-sale outing Ch24, the grab Ch25). **Both leads are now virgin-coded.**

- **The brevity is the mechanism:** she got out before it ever got close, which is exactly why there was no sex and why she's never been bare-close to a man. She reads a false bottom in a person the way she reads a cooked column; she clocked him and bolted.
- The asymmetry retired the old "Jae = experienced (two-year history)" lock. Asymmetry is now **temperament, not experience.**
- **Load-bearing line, Ch24:** *"I'd closed Ji-hwan in an afternoon."* (Already supports "short" — no edit needed.)
- **Ch03 stands unchanged.** A grabbed wrist isn't closeness; the virgin-coding holds.

Prose ripple (if drafting/revising these): Ch17 (three "two years" refs → "a few weeks" / "once"); Ch24 L57 ("two years of knowing exactly how thin I live" → "everything he'd ever known about exactly how thin I live"); Ch25 grip-memory re-mechanized onto **type-of-grip + lifetime freeze-response**, not duration. Approved Ch25 final: *"A grip like that teaches a body fast, the way a year on a register teaches it a float, and mine went still under it the way it had gone still under hands before, the old stillness, the trained kind, the kind a room watches and decides is consent."*

Repo status: this revision lives in `the-quiet-hours-CANON-SYNC-2026-06-17-jihwan-experience.md` (delivered to outputs) but is **not yet pushed** to the live repo, and Ch17/24/25 still carry the old wording. Treat this guide as authoritative on Ji-hwan until the repo catches up.

8. AUDIO-FIRST — THE HARD CONSTRAINTS (TTS / Speechify)

The chapter file is the audio script. It is pasted directly into Speechify. The body must be clean and speakable. Author-facing notes go in chat *after* the file, never in the paste block.

The verification battery — run after EVERY chapter

- **Zero asterisks** in the prose body.
- No **"A beat."** pause construction.
- No 🎧 in the prose (name the one 🎧 beat in chat only).
- **Song runtime kept vague** ("nearly whole," never 2:38 — no runtime digits).
- **No markdown headers** in the chapter body.
- Korean names **TTS-safe** (see table below).
- **Option-A leak words** scrubbed (tray/ballroom/manifest/catering through Ch29).
- **Jae-Guard clean** (no admiration leak; banked names not surfaced before release).
- **No spelled-out sounds** in heat scenes (no "mmm," "ahh," no onomatopoeia — render the *effect* in prose).

Header spec (exact)

```
Rule N: Title
<blank line>
Jae           ← or:  Do-yun ("Doha")
<blank line>
<blank line>
<body...>
```

No markdown headers, no narrator/voice labels. Chapter title is a "rule" — a joke on the surface, the chapter's thesis underneath. **One 🎧 standalone audio exchange per chapter** (a ~30-second dialogue beat that crackles read aloud) — name it in chat, never in the body.

The two Speechify personas

Persona	Voice	Settings	Note
Jae-wu — Geffen	dry, flat, controlled, wry	speed 0% to -5%, pitch 0% to -10%, auto-detection OFF	reads all odd chapters
Doha — Dominic	warm, charming, quick; softens on tender lines	speed +10-15%, pitch 0% to -5%, auto-detection OFF	reads even chapters

Dominic does not enter the book until Do-yun is an established known presence — the anonymous stranger in Ch1 stays voiced by **Geffen** to protect the deferred-identity reveal.

Session cap & splitting

Speechify Studio has a **~2,000-character session cap**. Pre-split each chapter into **≤1,900-character paste blocks, broken only at paragraph boundaries**.

Heat dial (TTS rendering)

Heat runs **floor 3 / ceiling 4** — verge-warm baseline; sensual *stays-in-the-room* at the 2–3 payoff scenes; **never explicit**. The charged detail (a half-inch of cup neither moves) does the work; the verge holds; fade-friendly. **Punctuation is the breath track** (comma, em-dash, fragment on its own line). Keep the two registers audible even at level 4 (one voice can't switch): Jae = stillness breaking / the count failing / dry frame; Do-yun = beats, rhythm, the song moving.

Group-chat fold (TTS fix)

Never use Name: chat blocks, ALL-CAPS, or bare standalone (parentheticals) — they garble playback and trip Speechify's multi-voice detection (it pitch-shifts mid-stretch). **Render group texts as the POV character reading the thread to us**, in one clean narrated paragraph, full sentences, each member's character carried by framing ("Sun got there first... Reo came in swinging... Yejun, dry as ever...").

Pronunciation table (priority names)

Name	Sounds-like	Name	Sounds-like
Jae / Jae-wu	JAY / JAY-woo	Do-yun	DOH-yoon
Yejun	YEH-joon	Hyun	HYUHN
Seungwoo	SUHNG-woo	Yun (surname)	YOON
Daon	DAH-ohn	SEORÉ	SUH-ray
Baek	BECK	Sori	SOH-ree
Yuna (Seo)	YOO-nah (Seo = SUH)	KAIROS	KY-rohss
Tae	TAY	Reo	REH-oh
Joon	JOON	Doha	DOH-hah

Ahn	AHN	Min-gyu	MIN-gyoo
Kang Mae-hwa	KANG MEH-hwah	Han-byeol	HAHN-byuhl

Fine as-is (skip): Sun, Noh, Director Oh, Mr. Goo.

9. PER-CHAPTER WORKFLOW (the standing pipeline)

When she sends **"Chapter N" + a file**, no further instruction is needed. Run the full pipeline:

1. **Pull the live repo** (tarball, cache-busted — see §10) before doing anything.
2. **Diff** the sent file against the canonical repo copy.
3. **Run the full verification battery** (§8).
4. **Deliver a clean output** to `/mnt/user-data/outputs/` and present it for download.

Same for revisions: read the live file first, never "fix" from memory.

10. HOW TO WORK WITH THE AUTHOR

Draft first; don't over-clarify. She steers at the macro/emotional level and trusts execution. Her prompts are terse, fragmentary, mobile/voice-to-text — **interpret them as intent and produce a draft, not a list of questions**. When phrasing is ambiguous, **name your interpretation explicitly before acting**. Reserve clarifying questions for genuine forks, and keep them to **one**. She corrects by subtraction ("no," not elaboration).

Corrections are durable, and the ripple is same-turn. When she corrects voice/character/canon — or when a chapter locks a new fact, resolves a conflict, or makes a continuity decision — apply it to the prose **and** record it in BIBLE + story-state-log + INDEX (plus BACK-HALF-ARCHITECTURE-LOCKED where it touches back-half canon) **in the same turn**. A stale index lies with confidence.

The repo is the source of truth.

- **Repo:** `github.com/deliah0129/the-quiet-hours` . All files live inside the `the-quiet-hour/` subfolder.
- Reliable no-auth bulk read (works under rate limiting): the tarball at

`codeload.github.com/deliah0129/the-quiet-hours/tar.gz/refs/heads/main` . **Append**
`?t=$(date +%s)` **to bust cache when verifying a push.** (Contents API rate-limits; raw
CDN lags pushes.)

- **You can read the repo but cannot write to it.** Every push is hers, via **Working Copy on iOS, rename-over method only** (never the Files app — it caused a duplicate crisis; the repo is currently mid-dedupe with ~118 duplicate-suffixed files).
- **Outputs go to** `/mnt/user-data/outputs/` . She pushes. **Never claim a file is “saved” or “pushed” until she confirms it.**
- Chapter filenames: `the-quiet-hours-chN.md` .

Demonstrate with before/after prose, not craft lectures. Concrete over abstract.

11. QUICK-REFERENCE CARD

Structure. 1st person, past tense, dual alternating POV. **Jae = odd chapters (dry/withheld, Geffen).** **Do-yun = even chapters (lush/poured, Dominic).**

The cast. KAIROS (5): **Tae** leader · **Reo** rapper (real name Joon; family runs Maeil Galbi) · **Yejun** dry strategist / deep-voice anchor · **Sun** warmth/maknae · **Do-yun** main vocal/visual/center. **Hyun** = Do-yun’s manager & surrogate brother (~38). **Seo Yuna** = reluctant arranged fiancée, reluctant ally (not a rival). Antagonist: **Ji-hwan** (Jae’s ex — brief, non-physical; turned on her).

The per-scene gate (run while drafting):

- Dialogue sparks but doesn’t override the charged-beat interiority?
- Interiority POV-correct — Do-yun pours on charged beats / Jae dry, short-burst, withheld?
- A feeling named-then-undercut **in-character** (not explained to the reader)?
- **Shows rather than tells** — nothing flagging significance, naming the character’s own arc, or glossing the moral?
- Banter **surrounds** the charged beat and goes silent for it — never lands on it, never displaces interiority?
- Do-yun faster/funnier, Jae dryer/sparer — **no motormouth in Jae’s narration?**
- Jae’s confession **suspicion-not-admiration** (until the arc earns the flip at Ch30)?

- Body joked-past or charged-and-restrained, not purple?
- One 🎧 exchange that carries aloud? Chapter title doubling as joke + thesis?
- Audio-first clean (the §8 battery)?

Banked-reveal schedule: idol/Seungwoo → **Ch22** · heir/Baek/Sori/Daon → **Ch27** · full detonation + Option-A → **Ch30** · Jae's lush-confession unlock → **Ch30**.

The two non-negotiables to never forget: (1) **Show, don't tell** outranks everything.
(2) **The firewalls** (Jae-Guard, Option-A, banked secrets) hold every chapter.